THE LEGAL AID SHEET

CAT ROBINSON-RUTELLA · OCTOBER 24, 2026 · ZYK-549

Legal-support investigation and case analysis, offered to counsel. The one-sheet that sells the analyst to the people who need her.

> "I should help lawyers. Utilize my intelligence and sell me like a detective. I wanna be a private investigator. I wanted to be Sherlock Holmes, and everything's a brain game."

1. THE ADVICE SHE GAVE HERSELF, PARSED OUT

Four moves, in her own words, dated Oct 24 2026:

1. **Stop spending the energy suing everybody.** The instinct to litigate everyone converts into a service FOR the people who litigate.
2. **Make herself useful to lawyers.** Not against them. The receptacle for her exactness is the case that needs it.
3. **Sell the intelligence as detective work.** Observation, verification, timelines, exhibit craft. The childhood plan, priced.
4. **The long arc is law.** Law school, the New York child advocacy board, legal aid. The sheet is the first rung of that ladder, not a replacement for it.

2. THE RECEIPT: AN ATTORNEY ALREADY ASKED HER

CORRECTED Oct 24 on the principal's word: it was not the attorney. It was the attorney's ASSISTANT at the New Jersey firm - the aide, not the lawyer - who asked *her*, unprompted, for help defining statutory and procedural concepts. When the definitions mattered inside a working law firm, the firm's own staff reached for her. That is the receipt, and it cuts wider: not just lawyers need this. People who have to define things properly need this. On circulation copies the firm is generalized; it is named only at the principal's election.

3. WORK PRODUCT ALREADY ON FILE

ARTIFACT	WHAT IT SHOWS COUNSEL
24-page attorney-facing brief, 9 documentary exhibits embedded	Full case-prep capability: classification analysis, timeline tables, sourced legal frame, agreement clause reading, a spoken version written for delivery by the attorney
Evidence inventory, E1 through E8, pending-slot discipline	Chain-of-custody thinking: every exhibit numbered, every gap named, nothing invented to fill a hole
Ten-number counsel contact sheet, all numbers live-verified	Verification habit: not one number placed on the sheet unconfirmed
Statute and forum-clock map	Doctrinal literacy: filing windows named with sources, claim elements mapped to facts, doctrines named before application
Consolidated case compendium	Command of a full documentary record, organized for a reader who was not in the room

Party names and matter details are withheld on circulation copies. Work product is confidential and engages through counsel.

4. THE METHOD

Everything is a brain game, run as discipline: observation before conclusion. Every load-bearing claim carries a citation checked against the live source, never the memory of a source. Every date is anchored to a record timestamp. Files are hash-verified so the record proves it has not been altered. A fixed error-classification system runs across the entire body of work, which is why the errors that get caught stay caught.

5. THE LICENSE MAP, NEW JERSEY

Private investigative work in New Jersey is licensed under the Private Detective Act of 1939, N.J.S.A. 45:19-8 et seq., administered by the New Jersey State Police Private Detective Unit in West Trenton. Requirements for the individual license: age 25, five years of qualifying investigative experience, character references, a $250 application fee, fingerprinting, and a $3,000 surety bond. Qualifying experience includes documented private-sector investigative casework and time served as a registered investigator employee under a licensed New Jersey agency.

The near-term door: the services above (research, case analysis, exhibit preparation, timelines for attorneys) run now, while agency-side casework banks the five years. The license is the five-year climb, not the entry gate. She is 27. The math is friendly.

6. THE MARKET, 2026

LANE	RANGE
Private investigator, national, standard work	$75-$250/hr, most between $95 and $150
Litigation support, testimony-adjacent investigator time	$200-$350/hr, half-day minimums
Senior digital forensics examiners with courtroom experience	$500-$750/hr
Her engagement terms	Rate card on file; deal floor per posted schedule

Engagements through counsel. This sheet is a capability statement, not legal advice. Sources: New Jersey State Police Private Detective Unit; New Jersey Licensed Private Investigators Association; 2026 digital forensics and private investigator rate guides.